AI IN EDUCATION · PRACTICAL GUIDE

Apple Intelligence

for teachers and school leaders

A pedagogically transparent guide — what stays on your device, what doesn't, and why that matters in a school context.

WRITE ASK SEE

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THE GUIDE

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HOW TO READ THIS GUIDE

Part 1 orients you: which devices, how to turn it on, and the single most important distinction — on-device vs. Private Cloud Compute vs. ChatGPT. Part 2 is the practical walkthrough, feature by feature, with classroom examples. Part 3 is for anyone responsible for school policy: what the GDPR implications actually are, where Apple's privacy story holds up, and the one place it doesn't.

01

PART 1

Get started

What runs Apple Intelligence, what it can actually do today, and — the important bit — how Apple's "on-device" claim actually works when you look closely.



Which devices run Apple Intelligence

As of October 2026, Apple Intelligence runs on a narrow slice of the Apple hardware you are likely to meet in a school. On iPad, you need an **M1 chip or later** — so an iPad Pro from 2021 onwards, or an iPad Air from 2022 onwards, or any recent iPad mini with Apple-silicon. On Mac, any machine with Apple-silicon (M1 or later) will run it. On iPhone, only iPhone 16 models or later, iPhone 15 Pro, iPhone 15 Pro Max, and iPhone Air are supported. The standard iPhone 15 is not.

The practical point for most school iPad fleets: the iPads most commonly deployed in one-to-one device programmes — the 9th and 10th generation standard iPads, and the older iPad Air with A-series chips — **do not run Apple Intelligence**. I say that at the front of this guide rather than in a footnote. If your fleet is in that group, this material is useful for policy and planning, but not something you can hand to staff to try this afternoon.

Language support has expanded since launch, with English available first and additional languages added over time. Because Apple adds new languages and regional features on a rolling basis, verify the current state on your own device — for the language you teach in — rather than trusting a document that is already a few months old. The simplest check: open **Settings → Apple Intelligence & Siri**. If that menu item appears at all, your device is compatible and you can see which languages are currently available to you.

PART 1 · SETUP

Turning it on (iPad-first)

On a compatible iPad, the setup is a single toggle, and the iPad then downloads its on-device models in the background. What Apple publishes is the storage the feature requires, not the size of that download: you need **up to 8 GB** on most supported iPads, or **up to 14 GB** on iPad models with M4 or later and at least 12 GB of unified memory. Apple gives no figure for how long the download takes, so plan around free space rather than a clock. The settings panel will read "Preparing" while it works; you can keep using the iPad normally.

1. Open **Settings** on your iPad.
2. Tap **Apple Intelligence & Siri**.
3. Toggle **Apple Intelligence** on and confirm.
4. Leave the iPad connected to WiFi and power while the model downloads.
5. When "Preparing" disappears, Writing Tools is live. Siri AI is not, on an EU iPad — Apple blocks it there. And Mail categorisation is a separate matter: Apple's own documentation never ties it to Apple Intelligence at all. Part 2 takes up both.

On Mac, the path is the same under **System Settings → Apple Intelligence & Siri**, and you need **up to 8 GB** of free disk space on most supported Macs, or **up to 14 GB** on Mac models with M3 or later and at least 12 GB of unified memory. On iPhone, the path is identical to iPad: **up to 8 GB** on most models, or **up to 14 GB** on iPhone 17 Pro, iPhone 17 Pro Max, and iPhone Air. You do not need to sign into anything new: Apple Intelligence runs under the Apple Account you are already using on the device.

One honest caveat before you proceed. The feature appears in Settings on any compatible device, but **some sub-features are gated by region or by age** — ChatGPT integration, for example, requires the user to be at least 13 (or the minimum age set by their own country) and sits behind a separate opt-in. The guide returns to these limits in Part 3, where they matter for school policy.

> **WHAT DEPENDS ON WHERE YOU TEACH**
> Whether your national or regional data-protection authority has published its own guidance on AI tools in schools — some have gone further than GDPR's general baseline, some haven't yet — depends on where you teach, not on anything Apple controls. Check what your own authority has said before you finalise a configuration. What doesn't depend on where you teach: your school remains the data controller for its students' data, and Private Cloud Compute doesn't change that. Build a periodic review of your configuration against your own authority's current guidance into your school calendar.

Private Cloud Compute — what it actually is

THE DISTINCTION THAT MATTERS

Apple talks about Apple Intelligence as an "on-device" product, and for most of what you will do in a classroom that description is accurate. But not for all of it. There are three distinct places your request can be processed, and knowing which one is in play for a given task is the difference between an informed user and one who is trusting a slogan. One clarification before the three: Apple has said Siri AI is built "in collaboration with Google and its Gemini models" — Apple does not say where that partnership sits, and the most likely reading is that it runs through the first two tiers below rather than as a fourth path alongside them.

1. **On-device processing.** The majority of everyday Apple Intelligence operations run entirely on the iPad, Mac, or iPhone in front of you. Most Writing Tools actions — rewrite, proofread, shorten — fall here, as do basic Siri requests and Notification summaries. Nothing leaves the device for these. Mail categorisation is usually assumed to run the same way, but Apple's own documentation doesn't say where it's processed — see Part 2. No request, no input, no output touches Apple's servers or anyone else's for the operations confirmed above. For the kind of quick parent-email rewrite a teacher does ten times a week, this is almost always what happens.

2. **Private Cloud Compute (PCC).** When a request exceeds what the on-device model can handle — a long summary, a complex Writing Tools operation, Image Wand generation — the system reaches for a more capable model running on Apple-controlled servers. Apple's published architecture for PCC has several distinctive properties: the request is encrypted end-to-end from your device to a PCC node; the servers run a **published, auditable software image**; the server discards the request data after returning its response, a property Apple calls *stateless computation*; and Apple publishes the server binary so independent security researchers can verify that what runs in production matches what was described. The full technical whitepaper sits at *security.apple.com*.

Three paths — a quick recap

3. **ChatGPT integration.** This is a separate, opt-in path, and — unlike the Google partnership behind Siri described above — it is the one external provider Apple documents as something a user actually chooses to turn on. When a user enables it, specific requests can be forwarded to OpenAI's servers. Apple anonymises the request in transit, but **OpenAI receives the actual content of what was sent.** This is a fundamentally different privacy model from the first two tiers and it deserves its own treatment; Part 3 returns to it in detail.

Two qualifications belong here. First, PCC does have stronger architectural guarantees than a typical SaaS API call — the auditability story is real and it is unusual in the industry. Second, "Apple cannot inspect your request" is nevertheless a **trust assertion** that depends on Apple's implementation matching what they have published. The audit story is what makes that trust somewhat verifiable rather than purely reputational, but it is not the same as the data never leaving the device.

A useful rule of thumb: a quick rewrite of a two-sentence parent email almost certainly stays on the iPad. Asking Apple Intelligence to summarise a ten-page PDF almost certainly invokes Private Cloud Compute. Anything that touches ChatGPT is clearly signalled in the interface and requires an explicit tap.

THE RULE OF THUMB

On-device for short and routine · **PCC** for heavy lifting · **ChatGPT** only when you tap. Part 2 tells you which path each feature uses; Part 3 tells you what that means for school policy.

Worth knowing (but outside this guide's scope)

Three features get a lot of attention in Apple's marketing but sit outside the pedagogical core of this guide. Mentioning them briefly so you can answer the inevitable staffroom questions.

Image Playground

Image Playground generates images from a text description. Apple no longer limits the picker to the original three named styles: its current style picker names examples like Any Style and Illustration, accepts a free-text style description, and now offers ChatGPT as its own style option inside the app. Apple's own styles still run through Private Cloud Compute. Classroom relevance stays narrow; students will often explore it on their own, and its usefulness for teacher-prepared materials is modest compared to dedicated image tools.

Genmoji

Genmoji creates custom emoji from a short text description, also via PCC. Low day-to-day classroom utility, though some teachers use them as personalised stickers in feedback.

Clean Up

Clean Up in the Photos app removes unwanted objects from a photograph. This is genuinely practical for tidying classroom photos before sharing them with parents, and most Clean Up operations run on-device.

The privacy profile of all three is the same as the analysis above: on-device where possible, PCC where the task demands more capacity, never ChatGPT unless the user explicitly invokes it.

THE TAKEAWAY FOR PART 1

Apple Intelligence is not one thing — it is a stack. On-device for most of what you do. PCC for the heavier tasks. ChatGPT, only when you say so. Keep that three-tier picture in mind as you work through Part 2, and Part 3 will land with far fewer surprises.

PART 1 · BRIDGE

Before you read on

Before we move into the feature-by-feature walk, a short checklist. If you can tick these boxes, Part 2 will read as practical guidance you can apply tomorrow. If you can't, come back to Part 1 first.

1. You know whether the devices in your school meet the hardware bar (iPad M1 or later; iPhone 15 Pro or newer; any Apple-silicon Mac).
2. You have located **Settings → Apple Intelligence & Siri** on at least one device and confirmed your working language is available for your use case.
3. You can articulate, in one sentence each, what on-device, Private Cloud Compute, and the ChatGPT integration mean — and why they are not the same thing.
4. You understand that "on-device" is a meaningful privacy property but not a magic one: the iPad still syncs, still backs up, still participates in iCloud unless configured otherwise.

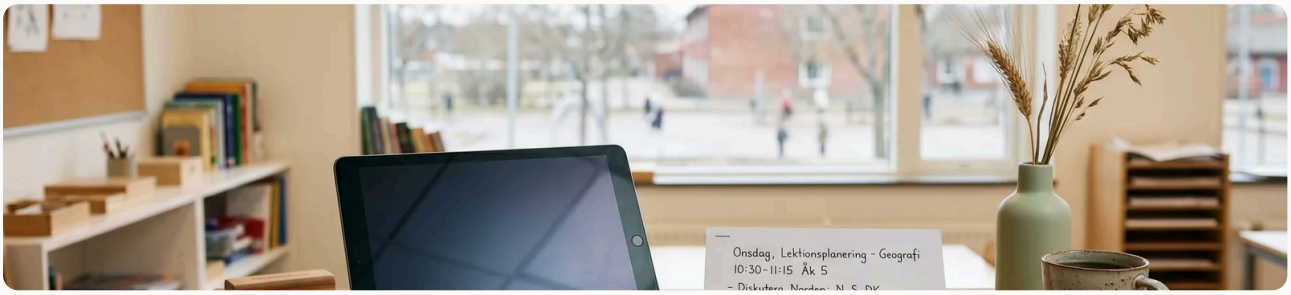
The rest of the guide assumes that foundation. Part 2 is structured around six features. For each one, you get: a plain description of what it does, five classroom examples drawn from real teacher workflows, a "Where it runs" callout so you always know which of the three paths is in play, and a short how-to for first use. Part 3 then steps back and addresses the policy picture — the DPIA-level questions, the ChatGPT exception, and five concrete decisions for your school.

> ONE HABIT WORTH BUILDING
> Before you press the button on any Apple Intelligence action, take a half-second to ask: does this belong on-device, in PCC, or with ChatGPT? The question gets quick with practice, and it is the single best defence against accidental disclosure.

PART 2

02 Work smarter

Six features that change day-to-day teaching work, with practical examples from real classrooms and a clear note on where each one processes your data.



1. Writing Tools

Writing Tools is the built-in rewrite, proofread, and summarise surface that appears wherever you can edit text on iPadOS — Mail, Notes, Pages, Safari text boxes, the Classroom app's messaging panel. It is not a separate app to open; it is a menu option that appears when you select text.

> POSSIBLY AFFECTED BY THE EU RESTRICTION
> Apple's Digital Markets Act notice for the EU lists "integrated tools for writing" among the Siri AI capabilities it blocks, with no published timeline. Apple's own text does not say whether that phrase means Writing Tools or Siri AI's separate writing integration, so treat Writing Tools' status on an EU iPad as unconfirmed rather than assuming it works.

Classroom examples

- **Rewriting assessment feedback:** a terse "Needs more detail" becomes warmer in two seconds via the Friendly tone option. The student reads it and actually engages with the comment instead of skimming past it.
- **Parent email in three registers:** write the draft once, then generate Professional, Friendly, and Concise variants. Pick the tone that matches the history you already have with that particular parent.
- **Tightening a learning intention:** paste a paragraph from the syllabus, request a summary, end up with one sentence students can reread between activities.
- **Proofreading in your teaching language:** works on the language you teach in and catches common agreement errors and clumsy constructions. Not a substitute for a language teacher's eye, but useful for your own drafts before they go out.
- **Expanding a bullet list:** turn a five-bullet outline into a coherent three-paragraph email for the morning briefing without rewriting from scratch.

WHERE IT RUNS · WRITING TOOLS

Short operations — rewrite, proofread, brief summarise — run on-device. Longer summaries across multi-page documents invoke Private Cloud Compute. Nothing is sent to ChatGPT unless you explicitly choose the "Compose with ChatGPT" option in the menu.

How to start

1. Select any text in any editable field on your iPad.
2. Tap **Writing Tools** in the callout menu that appears above the selection.
3. Choose an action — Proofread, Rewrite, Friendly, Professional, Concise, Summarise, or Key Points.
4. First use will ask you to confirm Apple Intelligence is enabled; after that it is a two-tap operation.

> On Mac: Writing Tools is available via right-click on any selected text, or from the Writing Tools icon that appears in the menu bar when text is selected in a supported app.

2. Siri AI

The refreshed Siri uses on-device intelligence to hold context across requests, understand natural phrasing, and act inside apps — opening specific documents, extracting information, and scheduling follow-ups without you having to switch apps yourself.

NOT AVAILABLE IN THE EU

Siri AI does not work in the EU on iPhone or iPad. Apple cites the EU's Digital Markets Act as the reason and has not published a timeline. If your school's iPads are in the EU, the classroom examples below describe a feature you cannot use.

Classroom examples

- **Context-aware scheduling:** "Move the Year 9 parent meeting to next Thursday and email the parents." Siri updates Calendar and drafts the Mail message in one step.
- **Cross-app retrieval:** "Find the lesson plan I wrote about photosynthesis last term." Pulls the Notes document without you hunting through folders or searching manually.

- **Quick definitions in class:** ask a technical question mid-lesson; the answer arrives without you leaving your lesson slides or breaking the flow for students.
- **Morning briefing:** "What meetings do I have today and are there any unread parent emails?" Returns both in one response, so the first five minutes of the day become a triage rather than a scramble.
- **Confirm before destructive actions:** when you ask Siri to send an email, the draft is shown first for approval. A sensible default for classroom use, where voice commands can easily be overheard by students.

> WHERE IT RUNS · SIRI AI
> The overwhelming majority of Siri AI requests run on-device. Complex queries may invoke Private Cloud Compute. The ChatGPT handoff is only triggered on an explicit prompt ("Ask ChatGPT about…") and shows a confirmation screen before sending. That confirmation can't be switched off under Siri AI — Apple's setting covers classic Siri only. Part 3 has the detail.

How to start

1. Hold the side button on your iPad, or say "Siri" if "Hey Siri" is enabled.
2. Watch for the subtle light that wraps the screen edges — that visual cue indicates the updated Siri is listening.
3. Speak naturally; you do not have to phrase requests as commands any more.
4. Review the response on screen and confirm any action that sends an email, a message, or a calendar invite.

> On Mac: Triggered via the menu bar icon or by pressing and holding the Globe key (the default shortcut). Same capabilities and the same on-device-first processing.

3. Mail categorisation and Priority

Apple Mail now sorts incoming messages into four categories — Primary, Transactions, Updates, and Promotions — and surfaces time-sensitive Primary messages at the top as Priority Mail. For a teacher with a flooded inbox after a field-trip announcement, the effect is immediate.

Classroom examples

- **Parent day fallout:** after announcing a field trip, eighty parent replies arrive overnight. The Primary inbox surfaces the three that ask actual questions; the rest — confirmations, no-shows, thanks — are grouped below.
- **Finding the email you need:** a parent asks "Did you get my email?" during pickup. Priority Mail has typically pinned it at the top already, so the answer takes five seconds rather than five minutes.
- **Conference notifications:** registration confirmations and receipts from professional development land in Transactions, where you only see them when you go looking.
- **Newsletter triage:** EdTech newsletters accumulate in Promotions, not in your main attention. You can still read them; they just no longer interrupt the working day.
- **Unreading made easy:** swipe left on a Primary item to send it back to unread if it needs a reply later. The context of why you left it is preserved in the Primary category.

> WHERE IT RUNS · MAIL CATEGORISATION
> Apple's support documentation doesn't say where categorisation itself is processed, or that Apple Intelligence is required to use it — the only restriction it states is that the feature "is not available in all countries or regions." Don't assume this one is entirely on-device; Apple hasn't confirmed it either way.

How to start

1. Open the **Mail** app on your iPad.
2. Tap the category name at the top of the inbox (it defaults to "Primary") to browse other categories.
3. To turn categorisation off entirely, open **Mail**, tap the icon at the top of an inbox, then choose **List View**.

4. Notification summaries

iPadOS now groups related notifications and shows a one-line summary of each group. A pile of twenty parent messages becomes one readable line that tells you what the group is about, so you can decide whether to open it now or later.

Classroom examples

- **Dawn catch-up:** open the iPad and see "5 messages from parents about tomorrow's trip" instead of five separate lines all demanding attention at once.
- **After-assembly sweep:** a run of Teams messages from the department gets summarised as "Three updates about Year 10 assessment dates" — enough to know whether you need to read now or at lunch.
- **Weekend boundary:** Monday-morning opening reveals "12 notifications, including 2 from the head teacher" — triage becomes obvious at a glance.
- **Group chat awareness:** a long group thread about staff party logistics becomes a one-liner, so you do not have to scroll through forty messages to confirm you are not needed.
- **What it can't do:** summaries occasionally read an urgent message as routine. Apple's own guidance is clear on this point: do not rely on summaries for safeguarding-sensitive categories. Open the messages themselves when the stakes are real.

> WHERE IT RUNS · NOTIFICATION SUMMARIES
> Entirely on-device. No notification content is processed off the iPad.

How to start

1. Open **Settings** → **Notifications** → **Summarize Notifications** and turn the feature on.
2. Tap **Choose Notifications to Summarize** to pick which apps get included.
3. Toggle individual apps on or off depending on whether you want their notifications summarised or kept in their raw form.

> On Mac: Available but less prominent; macOS notifications are themselves a lower-visibility surface. Most teachers will feel the difference on iPad rather than on the Mac.

5. Notes and Image Wand

The Notes app has gained an Image Wand that turns rough sketches or short descriptive text into polished illustrations — for handouts, whiteboard-ready diagrams, or worksheet graphics. It is the first image-generation tool to sit inside a note rather than in a separate app.

Classroom examples

- **Whiteboard diagrams:** a rough circle-and-labels sketch becomes a clean vector-style diagram you can drop straight into a Keynote slide without redrawing it.
- **Handout illustrations:** describe "a friendly robot reading a book" and Image Wand generates a classroom-appropriate illustration in seconds. Useful when you need a consistent visual style across a set of materials.
- **Worksheet headers:** generate a themed illustration for each week's worksheet pack without hunting through stock-image libraries or worrying about licences.
- **Visual anchors for a lesson:** quick, distinctive images make abstract concepts easier for students to reference during follow-up questions later in the unit.
- **Student-shared notes:** when you share a Note with a colleague or a student, Image Wand-generated visuals travel with the document. No separate image files to manage.

> WHERE IT RUNS · IMAGE WAND
> Image Wand generation runs in Private Cloud Compute. Your sketch or description is transmitted encrypted to Apple's servers, processed, and returned; the request data is discarded after the response. See Part 3 for the full privacy picture, including what this means for school policy.

How to start

1. Open **Notes** on your iPad and open a new or existing note.
2. Tap the Apple Pencil circle icon, or the Image Wand button in the toolbar.
3. Sketch a rough shape or type a short description of what you want.
4. Tap **Wand** to generate; pick the version you like best from the results.

> On Mac: Same Notes feature; trigger it via the Image Wand menu item. Mac generation feels slightly faster in practice but uses the same Private Cloud Compute path.

6. Visual Intelligence

Use the iPad camera — or, on newer iPhones, the Camera Control button — to point at real-world text, objects, or documents and get contextual actions. Translate, summarise, look up, identify. It is the feature that turns the camera into a research tool without you having to open a browser.

> THE EXPANDED LAYER IS BLOCKED IN THE EU
> Apple's Digital Markets Act notice for the EU blocks what it calls "an expanded Visual Intelligence experience," with no published timeline. Apple does not say how much of the basic recognition and translation below survives on an EU iPad once that layer is removed — most of the examples here read as the basic layer, but verify locally before building a lesson around them.

Classroom examples

- **Textbook page translations:** point at a paragraph in a geography textbook written in another language and get an English summary pitched for an EAL student in your class.
- **Lab equipment identification:** an unlabelled piece of science equipment in a shared-resources cupboard — point, get the name, and a short description of what it does.
- **Museum-trip companion:** point at an exhibition panel during a school trip and get a summary in plain language pitched for Year 6 reading level.
- **Restaurant menu translation:** staff training day abroad — useful for personal use during travel, with the same on-device mechanics as the classroom cases.
- **What it doesn't do well:** faces, student ID cards, or anything that could constitute personal data — deliberately limited. The guide recommends not pointing Visual Intelligence at anything that contains student names or images.

> WHERE IT RUNS · VISUAL INTELLIGENCE
> Basic recognition and translation happen on-device. Longer summarisation invokes Private Cloud Compute. If you explicitly tap "Ask ChatGPT" for a deeper explanation, that specific query is forwarded to OpenAI with a confirmation screen. Part 3 addresses the privacy implications of each path.

How to start

1. On newer iPhones, hold the **Camera Control** button on the side of the device.
2. On iPad, open the **Camera** app and point it at recognisable content.
3. Look for the Visual Intelligence button that appears in the camera interface when recognisable text or an object is in frame.
4. Tap the button and choose an action — Summarise, Translate, Identify, or Ask.

> On Mac: No direct equivalent — Visual Intelligence is a camera-first feature. Mac users get similar text-recognition through Live Text when images are imported, but the full Visual Intelligence surface is iPad and iPhone only.

At a glance

Before Part 3 takes you into the policy picture, a compact reference. Keep this page to hand when staff ask "but where does that one actually run?" — because the answer is not always obvious from the interface.

ENTIRELY ON-DEVICE

Notification summaries. The cleanest privacy profile in the suite — no request content leaves the iPad. Mail categorisation is usually assumed to run the same way, but Apple's own documentation doesn't confirm where it's processed.

ON-DEVICE FOR ROUTINE, PCC FOR HEAVY LIFTING

Writing Tools · Siri AI · Visual Intelligence. Short rewrites, quick requests, and basic recognition stay local. Longer summaries, complex queries, and extended Visual Intelligence responses invoke Private Cloud Compute.

PRIVATE CLOUD COMPUTE BY DEFAULT

Image Wand (Notes) · Image Playground · Genmoji. Generation is heavier than the on-device model handles, so these consistently reach the PCC layer — except Image Playground's ChatGPT style option, which isn't PCC at all.

CHATGPT — ONLY ON AN EXPLICIT TAP

Never invoked silently — every path starts with an explicit tap. The confirmation screen that follows can be disabled for classic Siri, via a setting Apple documents — but not under Siri AI itself, where that option doesn't exist. Lock the default at MDM level for school-managed devices — Part 3 covers the policy case for doing so.

Build one habit: when you press the button, name the path in your head. On-device, PCC, ChatGPT. Over a week, the three paths become automatic, and you never again use Apple Intelligence without knowing which one you invoked.

A week in the classroom, composed

Individually, each feature is modest. Composed across a working week, they change the shape of a teacher's day. The pattern is the same every time: each feature sits in a moment where you would otherwise break flow — open a browser, dig through folders, reach for a stock-image site, triage notifications manually. Each one saves thirty seconds to five minutes; several of them save those minutes ten or twenty times a day.

The composition looks something like this. Open your iPad in the morning. Notification summaries tell you, in one line, what happened overnight. Mail's Priority surface puts the two parent emails that need a reply at the top. Writing Tools rewrites each reply into the register you want. Siri AI finds last term's lesson plan without you scrolling through Notes — not on an EU iPad, where Siri AI is blocked (see the Siri AI entry earlier in this Part). Image Wand generates a diagram for tomorrow's lesson while you're on the bus home. Visual Intelligence catches a textbook translation you needed for an EAL student in period three.

None of these are headline features on their own. All of them together free a measurable chunk of the week — time that, as the introduction to the whole guide says, belongs to students rather than to admin.

THE ONE EXCEPTION TO START WITH

If you pick only one feature to build a habit around first, pick Writing Tools. It's the highest-frequency interaction point, it has the clearest privacy story (most operations on-device, PCC for the longer jobs, ChatGPT only on explicit request), and the quality difference over three weeks of daily use is the fastest signal you'll get that Apple Intelligence is worth your attention.

PART 2 · BEFORE YOU READ PART 3

What changes when you put the manager's hat on

Up to this point the guide has addressed the teacher at the classroom level: individual use, individual habit, individual rewrite of an individual parent email. That frame is where most staff will encounter Apple Intelligence first, and it is where the tool earns its daily value.

Part 3 steps back. It speaks to the school administrator, the principal, the digital-lead, and the DPO — the people who have to answer the question "is this allowed?" before a feature lands on a hundred classroom iPads. It addresses three things specifically. First, what happens to personal data at each of the three processing paths, and what that means under GDPR. Second, the single place the privacy story breaks — the ChatGPT integration — and why that path deserves a separate policy decision. Third, five concrete decisions your school needs to have taken before a staff rollout, written so the digital-lead can carry them into a senior-leadership meeting on a single sheet.

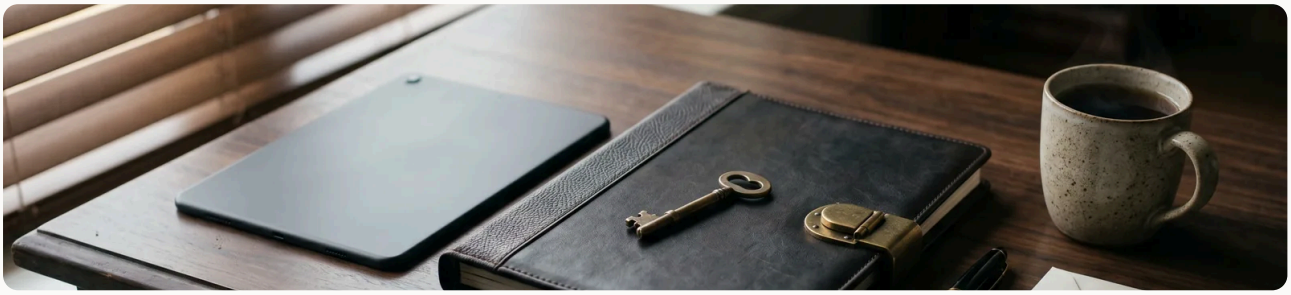
If you are a teacher reading this for your own classroom use, skim Part 3 anyway. The ChatGPT section in particular will make clearer *why* "Ask ChatGPT" surfaces with a confirmation screen rather than as a silent assumption. That is a design choice Apple got right, and the pedagogical reasons for the design are best understood once you have seen the policy picture the design is solving for.

Part 3 is six pages. You can read it in under ten minutes. The five policy decisions at the end are the takeaway; the rest is the reasoning.

PART 3

03 The GDPR angle — in practice

Why on-device processing matters under EU and national data protection law, where Apple's privacy story holds up, and the one place it breaks.



What stays on your device

A meaningful share of Apple Intelligence runs without anything leaving the iPad or the Mac in front of you. **Writing Tools** operations on short text — proofreading, tone rewrites, a brief summary of a few hundred words — are handled by the on-device model. **Notification summaries** are entirely on-device. **Mail categorisation** is the exception: Apple hasn't said where it runs, and Part 2 has the detail. Most everyday **Siri** requests stay local. **Visual Intelligence** performs basic recognition — text detection, common-object identification — without a round-trip to Apple's servers.

This matters under GDPR because the regulation defines **processing** very broadly — Article 4(2) covers almost any operation performed on personal data. But if personal data never leaves the controller's own systems (in practice, the teacher's iPad), the question of whether a third-party processor is involved narrows considerably. That does not exempt the operation from GDPR scrutiny, but it reduces the surface area of a Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) in a way cloud-based AI services cannot.

That said, "on-device" is not magic. The iPad is a controller-owned device, but it still backs up to iCloud unless the backup is disabled, still syncs across other devices signed into the same Apple Account, and still participates in the broader Apple ecosystem. On-device processing reduces exposure. It does not eliminate it, and a school's policy should treat it as one mitigation among several rather than as a clean answer.

When Private Cloud Compute is used

Some requests exceed the capacity of the on-device model. Rewriting multi-paragraph text, summarising a long document, generating an image with Image Wand, complex Visual Intelligence summarisation, and the more demanding Siri queries all invoke **Private Cloud Compute** (PCC). Apple's own documentation — published at security.apple.com alongside a technical whitepaper on the PCC architecture — describes the path the data takes once the device decides to hand off.

Technically, the request is encrypted end-to-end to Apple's PCC servers. Those servers run a specific software image that Apple has published for independent audit, so researchers can verify that the code running in production matches the code Apple claims to run. The computation is performed, the response is returned, and — according to Apple's stated architecture — the request data is discarded once the response is delivered. There are no persistent server-side logs of request content, and Apple engineers have no privileged back door into live requests.

Honestly framed: **PCC is still a data transfer to a processor.** The architectural guarantees are stronger than a typical SaaS API call — most SaaS APIs log requests and could be inspected by engineering staff — but from a GDPR perspective it is processing by Apple, and it is a transfer to Apple's infrastructure (Apple does not publish where its PCC nodes are located, so confirm current data-residency arrangements with your procurement contact before relying on anything specific in a DPIA). It should be referenced in the school's DPIA and lined up alongside the existing Apple Data Processing Addendum.

One pragmatic sentence for your policy document: *PCC is probably the strongest privacy architecture any major cloud-AI provider has deployed at scale — and it still isn't the same as nothing leaving the device.*

The one place the on-device promise breaks

This is where the on-device promise breaks

The ChatGPT handoff is triggered when a user explicitly taps **Ask ChatGPT** — surfaced by Writing Tools, Visual Intelligence, or Siri when the request exceeds what Apple's own models will handle. By default, iPadOS holds the request behind a confirmation dialog, and nothing goes to OpenAI until the user accepts it there — a deliberate design choice by Apple. Apple also documents a setting, **Confirm Requests** under Settings → Siri → ChatGPT, that disables this confirmation for classic Siri — but that option isn't available when using Siri AI itself, so for Siri AI specifically the confirmation can't be disabled. Which case applies depends on which Siri the device is running, and a school shouldn't assume the stricter one without checking. It is also the point where the privacy architecture of the rest of Apple Intelligence stops applying.

What actually happens once the user accepts: the specific text or image is sent to OpenAI. Apple anonymises the request at the network and account level — OpenAI does not see the Apple Account identity — but OpenAI receives the content itself. OpenAI's own logging, retention, and training policies then govern that content, not Apple's. The protections described in the PCC whitepaper do not carry over to this path.

The GDPR dimension is significant. OpenAI is a US-based processor, and transfers of EU personal data to US processors require specific legal mechanisms — Standard Contractual Clauses, adequacy considerations, and the ongoing Schrems II analysis of US surveillance law. An opt-in dialog on an iPad does not substitute for the school's own legal analysis.

The practical recommendation is therefore blunt: **disable the ChatGPT integration on school-issued iPads by default through Apple School Manager or your MDM**, and train staff to recognise the "Ask ChatGPT" prompt and decline it for anything student-related. This is the single most important configuration decision for any school rolling out Apple Intelligence.

What this means for student data

The working rule is simple: de-identify student data before any Apple Intelligence interaction, even when you believe the operation will run on-device. The distinction is between **teacher-work data** — planning documents without student names, generalised parent emails, your own meeting notes — and **student data**, which includes names, grades, behavioural notes, SEN plans, safeguarding concerns, and anything that could identify a child or their family. Teacher-work data is generally fine to process on-device. Student data should be de-identified or kept out of Apple Intelligence entirely.

Four reasons on-device processing alone does not make student data safe:

- **iCloud Backup** may include the document you just processed, and from that point on the data's journey is governed by iCloud's terms rather than the on-device model's architecture.
- Classroom iPads and cover-teacher devices are often **shared**, so material one teacher processed may be visible to another.
- **Accidental dictation pickup** during a lesson can send snippets of student discussion into a transcript you did not intend to create.
- The on-device model **does learn usage patterns locally** — not a data breach, but something to be aware of when the same device moves between teachers or across a role change.

A plain working heuristic for staff: if the document would be sensitive to send to a cloud service, apply the same discipline to Apple Intelligence interactions — even when you are told they run on-device. The habit is more reliable than a feature-by-feature mental model.

> ONE SENTENCE FOR STAFF TRAINING
> De-identify first; trust the architecture second. The on-device model is a backstop, not a green light.

A short word on the EU AI Act

GDPR is not the only EU law in play. The AI Act became applicable on 2 August 2026, and it sorts AI systems into four tiers: Unacceptable risk, High risk, Transparency risk, and Minimal or no risk. One obligation already binds every school that deploys an AI system, whatever tier it sits in: Article 4 of the AI Act's AI-literacy duty has applied since 2 February 2025. The tier that would actually reach a school — Annex III's high-risk category, which names education explicitly — is not due yet: the AI Omnibus pushed that date to 2 December 2027.

Say a school did put an AI system to one of the Annex III uses — deciding who gets access to education, or scoring exams, are the Commission's own examples — the obligations that attach before such a system reaches the market are the provider's under Article 16, not the school's. From 2 December 2027, what a school would carry, as the deployer, is Article 26 of the AI Act, which includes these five duties. Follow the instructions for use. Assign human oversight to staff with the competence, training, authority and support to exercise it. Retain the logs the school controls for at least six months. Inform staff and their representatives before putting the system to work. Tell the people subject to it that it is in use. Article 27 adds a fundamental-rights impact assessment before first deployment, and it applies whether the school is publicly run or an independent provider of a public service.

None of this says Apple Intelligence is a high-risk system today. That depends on how a school uses it, not on the product, and nothing published settles it either way. Know the shape of the obligations before someone asks the question.

Five policy decisions for your school

01 **Disable "Compose with ChatGPT" by default via MDM.** On school-managed iPads and Macs, use Apple School Manager or your MDM provider to set the default for the ChatGPT Extension to off. Staff can be trained to enable it deliberately for specific personal-device use cases, but the default should never be on.

02 **Document Apple Intelligence in your school's DPIA.** Most processing is on-device, but Private Cloud Compute constitutes a data transfer to Apple and should be referenced alongside your existing Apple Data Processing Addendum. Cite Apple's published PCC architecture — the security.apple.com documentation and the PCC whitepaper — as a risk-mitigation factor, not as a replacement for your own analysis.

03 **Produce a one-page staff guideline on what to paste.** Teacher-work content is fine; student data should be de-identified or avoided. Include three worked examples of acceptable prompts and three of prompts to avoid, with names and specifics drawn from your own school context. Pin it to your shared staff wiki and reference it in onboarding. Producing it also puts something concrete behind Article 4's AI-literacy duty, described earlier in this Part.

04 **Make iCloud Backup settings an onboarding topic.** Staff should understand that the iPad's iCloud Backup may include documents processed by Apple Intelligence. For personal devices that also handle school work, this is legitimately a matter of per-teacher judgement — but the default should be conscious, not accidental, and the school should offer a clear recommendation.

05 **Build in a termly review.** EU feature availability shifts, and ChatGPT integration mechanics may evolve. A thirty-minute calendar entry each term for the digital-lead to skim Apple's release notes and update the staff guideline is enough to stop the policy drifting out of date.

FAQ

Questions teachers ask

Ten of the questions that come up most often from teachers and school leaders working with Apple Intelligence in schools.

Does my iPad support Apple Intelligence?

M1 or later: iPad Pro from 2021, iPad Air from 2022, recent iPad mini. Most school-fleet iPads on A-series chips do not qualify. Quick check: Settings → Apple Intelligence & Siri. If the menu is there, your device is in. Rushing to upgrade is rarely the right move — most teachers gain more from Claude or Gemini in a browser than from waiting on a hardware refresh. Budget note: several server-based features — Siri AI, Intelligent Photo Editing Tools, Image Playground, and AFM 3 cloud models in Shortcuts among them — carry a daily usage limit, and Apple says expanded access to these will come at a fee in the future, with no date set. Plan for that before a fleet-wide rollout, not a pilot.

Is Apple Intelligence available in my language?

Language support varies by language and keeps expanding — check Apple's live language matrix for the language you teach in before planning a staff rollout. Siri AI itself is a separate case: it is blocked in the EU on iPhone and iPad. Apple cites the EU's Digital Markets Act as the reason, with no published timeline — see Part 2 for details.

Should I turn on the ChatGPT integration?

For personal adult-only use, judgement call. For school-issued iPads with any student-facing use, disable it by default through your MDM. The reason is straightforward: the ChatGPT integration sends specific requests to OpenAI, a US-based processor — not covered by Apple's Data Processing Addendum. Start with it off, and turn it on deliberately.

Can I use Apple Intelligence with student data?

De-identify first. Even on-device processing deserves the discipline you'd apply to a cloud service when the content involves names, grades, behavioural notes, SEN plans, or safeguarding concerns. iCloud Backup and shared devices mean material doesn't always stay where you put it. Teacher-work data is generally fine.

How does this compare to Claude or Gemini?

Different tool class. Claude and Gemini are general chatbots for open-ended thinking work. Apple Intelligence is an ambient assistant built into the device: Writing Tools, Mail, Siri, Visual Intelligence. Complementary rather than competitors — most teachers use both, chatbot for the hard thinking, AI for in-context nudges.

What about Apple Intelligence on my personal iPhone?

Relevant for adult productivity — parent emails on the commute, meeting prep on the bus. Not relevant for student-facing work. Your personal iPhone is generally not covered by your school's data processing agreements with Apple. Keep student data on school-issued devices with proper MDM.

Does Apple Intelligence train on my data?

Apple's public stance: no training on user data from Apple Intelligence requests, whether on-device or PCC. PCC requests are stateless and discarded. ChatGPT integration is different — OpenAI's own training and retention policies apply to that opt-in subset, and they evolve. Apple = no training. ChatGPT = depends on plan.

Is it covered by our existing data processor agreement with Apple?

Verify with your DPO and procurement. Apple's DPA for Education generally covers on-device and PCC processing. The ChatGPT integration is a separate relationship between user and OpenAI and requires its own analysis. Your DPIA should explicitly address the ChatGPT path as a distinct risk.

Can I turn off specific features while keeping Writing Tools?

Yes. Mail categorisation turns off inside the Mail app itself — tap the icon at the top of an inbox and choose List View, not a Settings toggle. Notification summaries live under Settings → Notifications → Summarize Notifications, with per-app control under Choose Notifications to Summarize. The ChatGPT path has its own setting under Settings → Siri → ChatGPT Extension. Sensible rollout default: master on, Writing Tools on, Mail categorisation off, ChatGPT off.

Where do I get help if something goes wrong?

Apple's own documentation at *support.apple.com/en-us/121115*; the technical privacy architecture at *security.apple.com*. For school-specific questions — policy, DPIA, rolling out across a staffroom — reach out via *choosewise.education*. For MDM-specific configuration, your device provider (Jamf, Mosyle, Intune, ASM) has Apple Intelligence documentation and profile options.

"The honest answer to 'Is it private?' is 'Mostly — here's when it isn't.'"

— Johan Lindström, October 2026

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